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MARIA PAULA SUAREZ MACIAS

UNIVERSIDAD IBEROAMERICANA CIUDAD DE MEXICO

9TH SEMESTER

MEXICO

LAW DEGREE

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TITLE

Health influence on social media and self-medication among young adults in Mexico

RESEARCH PROBLEM

Self-medication is defined as the consumption of medications by one's own decision or on the recommendation of a third party, without the intervention of a physician [1]. Not all self-medication is high-risk; however, when carried out without adequate information, it can generate multiple risks, such as choosing an inappropriate medication, using incorrect doses, causing interactions, adverse reactions, or delaying the seeking of medical attention.

The Mexican study by Farías Ochoa notes that self-medication among young people requires attention, and that easy access to medications, together with digital platforms, creates new ways of obtaining and sharing information about their use [2]. Social media is no longer used only for entertainment; social media is now a daily part of how young adults access information, especially for health-related information, where recommendations, personal experiences, and content related to medications and treatments circulate.

Young adults are a particularly relevant population for examining this phenomenon. According to research by the Pew Research Center, 40% of U.S. adults have at some point gotten health and wellness information from influencers or podcasts [3]. Among those who consume that content, 65% say they trust it "somewhat," while 10% trust all or most of it. This justifies why we should study not only exposure but also trust. The problem is not solely the health content that is present on social media, but that this content is used as a reference for making decisions about taking the medication.

In Mexico, research already exists on self-medication and social media among university students. Farías Ochoa´s study identified practices of exchanging information, experiences, and recommendations related to medications. That work was exploratory and qualitative in nature, focusing on university students [2]. For this reason, there is a need to study quantitatively whether a relationship exists between exposure to health content on social media, the trust young people place in that content, and their self-medication practices, focusing on Mexican young adults.

EXISTING LITERATURE

The article "#WhatIEatinaDay: The Quality, Accuracy, and Engagement of Nutrition Content on TikTok" analyzed the quality and accuracy of nutrition content posted on TikTok. The study found significant quality problems: only 36% of the content evaluated was classified as completely accurate, while a substantial proportion contained partially or completely inaccurate information. In addition, health and wellness influencers represented the most frequent type of creator [4]. Separately, a study on sinusitis-related content analyzed 221 TikTok videos and found that posts made by non-medical influencers tended to be of

lower quality than those created by health professionals. Among educational videos posted by non-medical influencers, only 46.7% were considered factual [5].

Taken together, these studies show that platforms like TikTok have become significant sources of health and nutrition information for adolescents and young adults. However, some of the content they are exposed to is not necessarily backed by scientific evidence and may be shaped by dynamics specific to digital platforms. This raises concerns about the quality of the health information available and about how that information may relate to users' health decisions.

Several studies have examined the relationship between searching for health information online and how people use medications. The study conducted in Turkey on the effects of online health information seeking worked with 462 adults from Sakarya, Turkey, using both in-person and online surveys. It measured three variables: online health information-seeking behavior, rational medication use, and patient activism. The authors found that greater online health information seeking was positively associated with more rational medication-use practices. However, they also caution that the quality of information available online is a relevant factor, since reliable content can support appropriate decisions, while incorrect or unverified information can generate misinformation and negatively affect health outcomes. These findings suggest that access to digital health information does not necessarily produce negative consequences, but rather that its effects may depend on the quality of the information and users' ability to evaluate it [6].

Recent studies have also examined the role of credibility and trust in how young adults receive health information on social media. Pfender and Bleakley found that young people use influencers as a source of health information, although factors such as lack of credibility, sponsored content, and the need to critically evaluate the information can influence their willingness to follow their recommendations. These findings suggest that it is relevant to analyze not only exposure to health-related content, but also the level of trust users place in the information and in those who share it [7].

In Mexico, Farías Ochoa examined the relationship between socio-digital platforms and self-medication among university students through an exploratory study with a qualitative approach. The research used ethnography, interviews, and observation of interactions on Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok, and identified practices such as asking questions about medications, seeking guidance on dosage, promoting purchases, and sharing experiences related to their use. The study included more than 70 university students between the ages of 19 and 25 and analyzed 120 digital interactions. Its results suggest that socio-digital networks can function as spaces where young people obtain, share, and reinforce information related to self-medication. However, because of its qualitative nature and its exclusive focus on university students, there is still room to examine this phenomenon in a broader population of Mexican young adults and through a quantitative approach that would allow for examining

the relationship between exposure to health content on social media, the trust placed in that content, and self-medication practices among Mexican young adults [2].

RESEARCH QUESTION

What is the relationship between exposure to health-related content on social media, trust in that content, and self-medication practices among young adults in Mexico?

METHODOLOGY

The research will have a quantitative, cross-sectional, and correlational approach. Its objective will be to analyze the relationship among three main variables: exposure to health-related content on social media, the trust placed in that content, and self-medication practices. As a correlational study, it will not seek to demonstrate that social media causes self-medication, but rather to identify possible associations among these variables. The information will be collected through an anonymous online survey.

The population of interest will consist of young adults between 18 and 29 years old who reside in Mexico and use at least one social media platform. The goal is to obtain approximately 120 to 150 participants. The survey may initially be distributed among university students, acquaintances, family members who fall within the age range, and social media contacts. In turn, participants will be able to share it with other people who meet the inclusion criteria.

The questionnaire will be divided into four sections:

I. General information: age, gender, education level, and state or region of residence.
II. Exposure to health content: platforms used, frequency of encountering information about health, medications, symptoms, or treatments, and the type of account posting that content.
III. Trust in the content: how reliable they consider the health information found on social media, whether they verify that information through other sources, and how willing they would be to follow a recommendation.
IV. Self-medication: whether, during the past 12 months, they used any medication without first consulting a health professional, how often, and whether any of those decisions were related to information found on social media.

Participation will be voluntary and anonymous. Before responding, participants will receive information about the purpose of the study and must provide their consent. No names or other personally identifying information will be requested, and they may withdraw from the survey at any time.

RESEARCH TOPIC

This research addresses a current problem related to the growing use of social media as a source of health information. Analyzing the relationship between exposure to this content, the trust young people place in it, and self-medication practices can contribute to a better understanding of how digital environments are related to health decisions of young adults in Mexico. The results could be useful for strengthening health education and digital health literacy strategies, as well as for promoting more informed decisions about medication use.

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